INNOVATION AT THE EDGE

The world's biggest problems also happen to be its biggest opportunities. Salim Ismail, who has spent seven years in the Silicon Valley, worked at Yahoo and sold a company to Google, believes that big changes can be brought about through cutting-edge technologies like Artificial Intelligence—but these have to be nurtured on the edge of organisations, not as their mainstream operations. At the India Today conclave, he spoke about various challenges facing the country, like healthcare, education, clean water, energy, poverty, and how technology can hasten the finding of solutions.

"We're rearchitecting our workflows to now go AI-to-AI. We don't need the human in the middle. They're too inefficient, are error-prone, they have politics. They get sick and take vacations and unionise," he says. "What's going to happen is we're going to automate all of our workflows, especially with knowledge work. Humans will monitor dashboards and handle exceptions."

But tapping into new opportunities, especially in large corporations, is not easy, because these organisations are immune to change. A disruptive idea can flourish in a company only by fighting back the 'immune system' within that company, says Ismail. Outlier teams can be developed within big organisations so they have the freedom to blossom. Apple has been the master of this technique. "They form a small team that's very disruptive and put it at the edge of the organisation," says Ismail. "They will keep them secret and tell the team to go disrupt another industry, whether it's watches or payments or retail." That's how change happens when no one's looking. ■

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- If you try anything disruptive in a legacy environment, the immune system attacks you. Our organisations are designed to resist change
- All our workflows have been human-to-human. Now we're making that AI-to-AI. Humans will only monitor dashboards and handle exceptions
- ATM machines didn't kill bank teller jobs as costs went down and more bank branches opened. That can happen with major automation also



SALIM ISMAIL ▲

Founder, OpenExO; Founding Executive Director, Singularity University

> **100 years ago, it took 100,000 people to make a billion-dollar company. Then it got down to 10,000. Today, it can happen with about three**
>
> **We've been using AI as a tool up till now. But the tech is at a point of recursive self-improvement. You don't need humans anymore**